

CATWALK
A lioness crosses a road in Liliya village, Amreli district, in the Greater Gir region, while villagers oblivious to her presence walk on

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LITICS

THE THRIVING POPULATION OF ASIATIC LIONS IN GIR HAS BEEN A WILDLIFE SUCCESS STORY for several years now. Ironically, this very triumph of conservation has now become somewhat of a liability. The number of Asiatic lions has steadily risen over the past five decades in the last abode of the species. They increased from 284 in 1990 to 674 as per the 2020 census. But human population, industrialisation and urbanisation have also risen in tandem, leading to an inevitable man-lion conflict that is proving to be increasingly detrimental both to the lions and the humans. The lions have also fallen prey to deadly diseases such as the canine distemper virus by virtue of being cooped up in a single geographical region.

To deal with this compound set of problems, several deliberations have been held to relocate the lions to other sites, chiefly the Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh. But Gujarat has been stalling the effort on some pretext or the other, despite the Supreme Court order to the effect in 2013. The state has been reluctant to part with its lions, asserting that they are part of the Gujarati *asmita* (pride). Perhaps to end that stalemate, Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced Project Lion on the lines of Project Tiger on India's 74th Independence Day in 2020. As part of this ambitious plan, three "gene pool" sites would be set up at Rampara in Saurashtra, and Sakkarbaug and Satveerada in Junagadh for breeding lions. Six new potential sites have also been identified, including the Madhav National Park and Gandhi Sagar Wildlife Sanctuary (WLS) in MP, the Sitamata WLS, the Mukundra Hills Tiger Reserve and the Kumbhalgarh WLS in Rajasthan, and the Jessore-Balaram Ambaji WLS in Gujarat. However, the Gujarat government has come up with its own solution this year. Their lions will still not go out of Gujarat, if they have to be relocated, they could be sent to Barda, another sanctuary within Gujarat! It is not the solution it is being made out to be, say wildlife experts.

Located around 100 kilometres from Gir, 192.31 sq. km of forest area in Barda was declared a sanctuary in 1979. A report prepared by the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), 'Lion@2047: